

DIGITAL MEDIA, CULTURAL THEORY AND EDUCATION

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Assignment question one:

Choose a media and/or cultural theorist whose work you find particularly valuable in the fields of Media and/or Cultural Studies. Explain why you consider their work to be of particular value and show how their work helps you to analyse a contemporary cultural text, object, event or practice.

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Roland Barthes and Cultural Studies

Introduction

In this assignment I review the theoretical contribution of Roland Barthes to Cultural Studies and apply some of his concepts to the analysis of a photograph. Barthes is regarded as a major figure in the field of Cultural Theory for his contribution to the development of theoretical approaches to language, signification and representation (Hall 1997; Gray 2003; Storey 2009). Barthes is an actor of post-war French intellectual ferment which has transformed our understanding of culture, society and politics; his name is associated with structuralism and poststructuralism, and with authors such as Lévi-Strauss, Foucault or Derrida. These movements are characterised by a critique of Modernity and a renewed understanding of the 'relationships among language, power, social practices, identities, and inequalities' (Andreotti 2011).

My personal interest in Barthes's work stems from my interest in the relationship between education and social change. Barthes's critical engagement with cultural texts illuminates how 'critical literacy' can be applied and taught. Critical literacy is defined by Souza (2007: 4) as 'a socio-culturally situated practice involving the ongoing negotiation of meaning in continuously contested sites of meaning construction'. Sites of meaning construction refer, here, to cultural texts in the broad sense: to linguistic texts, images, cultural artefacts or social practices. Critical literacy, in the broad sense, therefore concerns the ability to read all these texts, and ask: Whose version of reality is represented? In whose name? In whose interests? What ideology informs it? What are the implications in terms of power and domination? How can this be contested? (Andreotti 2011).

This assignment is in two parts. In the first part I first outline the theories constituting the intellectual context in which Barthes produced his work, then I highlight and evaluate Barthes's own contribution. In the second part I apply these notions to the analysis of a photograph and illustrate how meaning can be contested and negotiated in the contemporary context of social media.

Part I

Marxism

Barthes is a figure of French intellectual life in the post WWII era, a period dominated by the influence of Sartre and Marxism. Sartre develops a historical materialist critique of literature (Sartre 1948). Under the *Ancien Régime*, the novel is an act of rebellion, it promotes the values of the then dominated Bourgeoisie. Conversely, in the 19th century, the Bourgeoisie has become the dominant class and the novel is now serving its ideological interests by promoting liberal values and representing the world in a light favourable to established power. Sartre's approach on cultural production resonates with Gramsci's concept of 'cultural hegemony'. Hegemony, here, means 'the success of dominant classes in presenting their definition of reality, their view of the world, in such a way that it is accepted by other classes as "common sense"' (Goldberg n.d.). While departing from Sartre's view on literature, and focusing more on questions of form, style and language (Allen 2003), Barthes's approach to culture remains concerned with questions of social class and with the working of ideology through representations of Bourgeois worldview, notably, in *Mythologies* (Barthes 1957).

Linguistics

A determining influence, on Barthes as well as on intellectual life as a whole since the 1950s, is Saussure's theory of language, which laid the foundations of structuralism and semiotics; it is based on a number of key concepts.

Firstly, Saussure's theory makes a distinction between *langue* and *parole*. '*Langue* refers to the system of rules and conventions which is independent of, and pre-exists individual users; *parole* refers to its use in particular instances' (Chandler 2007: 8). This notion is central to structuralism; it situates each event — *parole* — in the context of an overarching structure — *langue* — which determines its value.

Another corner stone concept of Saussure's theory is his model of the sign. The sign is viewed as the association of a signifier (material element) and a signified (a concept), in a process of representation (Saussure 1996). The signifier represents the signified which is itself a representation of things in the world. This latter representation is both present in our minds, in our 'theoretical model' of the world allowing us to make it intelligible, and present in culture, in the mind of all those who share it, allowing us to communicate (Hall 1997).

Importantly, for Saussure, there is nothing in the sign that intrinsically confers it meaning. Meaning is determined by the relations and differences between the signs within the structure at both levels of representation. Thus, the sign *table* will signify insofar as it is different from *cable* or from *label*, but also insofar as its value is determined by its relation with *chair* or *desk*. Meaning, then, is differential and relational (Hall 1997).

Additionally, a feature of Saussure's language theory is the two axes on which signifiers articulate their differences: the syntagmatic and paradigmatic axes. 'While syntagmatic relations are possibilities of combination, paradigmatic relations are functional

contrasts' (Chandler 2007: 84). On the former axis, signifiers relate to one another 'intratextually', while in the latter, they refer to signifiers absent from the text: 'intertextually' (Chandler 2007: 84).

Finally, the arbitrariness of the sign, although disputed (Chandler 2007), is another key aspect of Saussure's model. It establishes that the association of a signifier and a signified is a contingent social construction. A concept can be represented by any signifier, so long as a code is shared by a 'semiotic community' (Benveniste 1952). Thus, Hall (1980: 121) argues that certain codes 'may be so widely distributed in a specific language or culture, and...learned at so early an age that they appear not to be constructed ... but "naturally" given'. The notion of arbitrariness loosens and denaturalises the relationship between language and the world out there.

Structuralism

The study of structures, 'how things get organized into meaningful entities — as well as the structural relationships between things' posits that things mean by virtue of underlying principles that can be analysed (McGowan 2006: 3). This approach, formalised by Saussure and focused on language, was then extended and generalised. Propp (2000), for example, carried out in the 1940s a structural analysis of a large data base of folk literature and fairy tales in order to identify the narrative principles on the basis of which meaning is produced across this literary genre, shifting the focus from *what* texts mean to *how* texts mean and revealing the structures through which meaning comes about (Barthes 1985). Lévi-Strauss (1958; 1962) expands Saussure's model to anthropology. In his study of society and culture, he considers social phenomena as signs, constituted of a signifier (a form) and a signified (a symbolic content) which he dissociates and analyses according to their relationships to other signs in a system of meaning, to their value in a structure of social and cultural practices. The seemingly natural relation between form and content is broken down to reveal the function of social practices in semiotic systems (Barthes 1985). Lévi-Strauss's anthropology provoked a revolution in the social sciences and in philosophy: structuralism.

Poststructuralism

Structuralism dominates philosophy in the 1950s and 1960s. Limitations to structuralism, however, are pointed out and theorists such as Foucault or Derrida propose ways to overcome these limitations while keeping a constructivist approach concerned with signification, representation and the centrality of language (Rylance 1994). A limitation most pointed out is the inability of structuralism to account for changes in the structure over time. Saussure's model is mostly synchronic (Hodge and Kress 1988), it considers all the elements of the structure at one particular time, and tends to leave aside diachronic considerations.

Foucault develops the concept of 'discourse'. Discourses are structures of meaning which articulate language, social practices, knowledge and power. They are 'practices

that systematically form the objects of which they speak' (Foucault in Storey 2009). Foucauldian discourses also produce 'subject positions': positions from which meaning can be produced by a subject in relation to the set of significations made possible by the discourse. Some of the limitations of Saussure's synchronic structural model are here overcome as Foucault develops the idea of 'discursive formations', which are signification structures that co-exist in one historical period or supplant one another over time. Hence, there is a medical discourse in the 18th century and a medical discourse in the 19th century; there is a discourse on justice and a discourse on biology both existing at one time.

Derrida challenges the idea of the structure itself. For Derrida (1967: 409), the concept of structure implies a centre from which it can be defined as a unified whole; Derrida challenges the 'structurality of the structure'. While not rejecting Saussure's or Lévi-Strauss's work on meaning and representation, Derrida shows their approach assumes a 'transcendental signified' from which, ultimately, meaning derives. Since structuralism posits the existence of a structure, it posits the existence of a centre, for a structure *without* a centre is unthinkable. This transcendental signified, operates as the ultimate source of meaning in the same way that 'God' or 'Essence' had been transcendental signifieds in previous Western philosophical traditions. This centre, which organises the coherence of the system, is the point towards which every sign points, and where interpretation stops. The centre of a semiotic structure implies the idea of 'Truth' to interpretation. By dissolving the idea of a centre, Derrida, breaks up the formal relation between the signifier and the signified posited by Saussure. A signified is but another signifier. Meaning can never be fixed, there is no ultimate signified where interpretation stops, the signified always stands for something else.

Barthes's contribution

Inspired by Saussure and Lévi-Strauss, Barthes develops structural analyses and signification theories in various domains of cultural production. His approach is that of an anthropologist; he generalises semiotic analysis to all aspects of culture: literary texts, cinema, photography, media, and social practices, since 'all human practices in society are mediated, that is they are always already contained within systems of signification' (Allen 2003: 60).

For Barthes (1985), a text is a *parole* that refers to a *langue*, the wider cultural context which makes meaning possible. In his analyses Barthes is concerned with how a text relates to this cultural language. Meaning is where any aspect of a text refers to another element, either in the text or in the culture necessary to read it; meaning is one term of a correlation — a *citation* (Barthes 1985). A key notion in Barthes's oeuvre is the distinction between denotation and connotation. From Saussure's model of the sign, Barthes develops the model of a second order meaning (connotative) that builds on the basis of literal meaning. Barthes (1985) notes, following Saussure, that any system of signification is constituted of a plane of expression (signifier) and a plane of content (signified), and that signification results from the coincidence of the two planes — the sign. Barthes then posits a second level of signification where new content is ascribed to the sign

resulting from the first level signification. The sign of the first level is full (Barthes 1957), it contains a signifier and a signified, on the second level, however, it becomes the empty receptacle, the signifier, for connoted content.

The way connotative meaning operates is what really structures a text for Barthes. In *S/Z*, Barthes (1970) argues that the possibilities of interpretations created by the connotative structure he tries to reveal, is the quality that makes Balzac's novel still contemporary and constitutes the essence of Literature. Similarly, in his analysis of images from Eisenstein's films, Barthes (1977d) argues that the 'filmic', which ultimately structures the film, resides in a superior level of meaning which is above description or representation.

Photography

Barthes made a significant contribution to the analysis of photography (Hall 1997; Storey 2009). What characterises photography is its 'imitative' nature. Barthes (1977a: 17) calls it 'a message without a code' to stress the difference with verbal language which divides reality into units of meanings, transforms them into signs and organises them grammatically. In contrast, the mimetic power of photography gives the illusion it is purely denotative; hence the image of a red rose represents a red rose. Barthes nonetheless insists connotation is always part of the signification process 'for everyone from a real society' possesses the symbolic knowledge which extends 'the letter' of the image and makes meaning a social phenomenon (Barthes 1977c: 42); hence a red rose also represents passionate love. Moreover, a photograph is always a construction, it is the representation of but one version of reality. This construction is the result of a series of choices and material conditions at the level of production, diffusion, or technical choices such as framing, staging, and so on.

Barthes, then, sees two orders of meaning in the iconic message: the literal, denotative or perceptual message, and the symbolic, connotative or conceptual message (Barthes 1977c). He also argues that a linguistic message, in the form of caption, title, subtitles, etc., is needed to limit or guide the interpretation, to 'anchor' the meaning of the iconic message. Barthes argues that visual signifiers are too polysemous, that we live in a civilisation of language and writing on which, ultimately, signifying practices rely. Indeed, Barthes (1977c: 38) finds the idea of the 'civilisation of the image' inaccurate. In contrast, Kress and van Leeuwen (1996: 18) insist the image has an independent meaning structure: it may be 'connected with a verbal text, but in no way dependent on it'. The authors claim their approach allows for a finer analysis of meaning construction as a complex social phenomenon, since the conflicts of social life are sometimes reflected in the contradictions between the iconic and the linguistic message. The autonomy given to visual representation has allowed the authors to develop a 'grammar of visual communication' and to contribute valuable analysis tools. One could argue, nonetheless, that the co-presence of a linguistic and of an iconic message forms a system; that meaning cannot be considered outside the structure it forms.

Ideology

In *Mythologies*, Barthes (1957) demonstrates how second order signification is the conduit for ideology. Here the author combines structural theory of representation with a Marxist outlook on the social world, and critiques Bourgeois capitalist society, consumerism, but also ideologies of colonialism and patriarchy. Whether in the media or in social practices of 1950s France, Bourgeois values are injected in representations in order to shape people's subjectivities. The power of ideology resides in its concealment and it finds in second order meaning a place where reading can always be denied or contested, as opposed to literal meaning. Bourgeois values are pervasive, yet the process of representation conceals their specific origin as they pass from the real to representation. The purpose of ideology is to make the values of the dominant class perceived as common sense, to universalise and naturalise *one* version of reality. Myth is for Barthes a system of representation that eternalises historical processes and naturalises cultural constructs; the seeming naturalness of language, the mimetic power of photography, in sum, the literal description of reality that a naïve realist view on representation assumes, is what hides the depth and density of representation and its power in shaping what we believe is real.

Poststructuralism

Barthes's involvement in the development of poststructuralist approaches to semiotics is demonstrated in *S/Z* (1970) or in *'the Death of the Author'* (1977b). Poststructuralism challenges the binary relation between the signifier and the signified posited by Saussure (Storey 2009). Since a signifier refers to another signifier, objective interpretation is challenged; meaning cannot be stable anymore. Barthes (1970) insists that meaning lies with the many ways in which a text can be interpreted. Meaning is not in the text but in the mind of the active reader who (re)constructs the text in a subjective and culturally situated manner. This is in direct opposition to classical approaches which posit that meaning lies, in the last instance, in the intention of the author. Barthes (1977b) definitely rejects the idea of the author as a source of meaning holding 'truth' about interpretation. He 'deconstructs' the 'author' as 'transcendental signified' — as the end-point to interpretation that stabilises meaning, as the ultimate authority. Moreover, the contexts within which meaning is re-constructed are themselves unstable. New texts and new cultural conditions are produced which alter the ways in which subjectivities are formed and therefore, the ways texts are read. To read is to discover a network of *intertextual* relations: 'Meaning becomes something which exists between a text and all the other texts to which it refers and relates, moving out from the independent text into a network of textual relations' (Allen 2000: 1).

Conclusion to part I

Barthes's efforts to define and classify concepts, to produce theories of signification, although critiqued for seemingly trying to achieve scientific formality (Rylance 1994;

Allen 2003), have contributed to a deeper understanding of language and to moving away from a naïve realist view on representation. Meaning is not in the essence of things in the world, but a social and historical construction conveyed in language, signs and representation. Meaning relies on shared codes — culture. Barthes's work consisted in revealing these codes, this unexamined 'conceptual framework' (Culler 2002: 8) through which we make the world intelligible, and concealed by the seeming naturalness of representation. Every representation is the representation of one version of reality, and conceals alternative versions. Denaturalising signs, nonetheless, 'can reveal whose realities are privileged and whose are suppressed' (Chandler 2007: 11). Barthes's work on representations reveals how we are trapped in culture, in ideology — we are irreducibly separate from the real by representation. A representation is but one aspect of the real which acquires a special truth value by virtue of its mere positive existence as a representation — every *parole* is potentially mythical; what is said about the world becomes the world. This resonates with Derrida's idea that there is no clear distinction between descriptive and performative utterances (Royle 2003) — every *parole* transforms the world.

An important contribution of Barthes to Cultural Studies is also to have shifted the focus of literary critique from aesthetic considerations to meaning and how it is produced, in a materialist, immanent analysis of culture. Revealing the historic, material and political conditions of production of cultural objects, contributes to a desacralisation of 'high culture' and 'art', and to placing them on the same anthropological level as any cultural production. This approach is echoed by founders of British Cultural Studies with the works of Williams (1960) or Hall (1998).

However, in contrast with Hall (1996;1998), Barthes places little to no weight on individual agency. Barthes seems to see the transformations of society (mass consumption, American-influenced modernisation) as solely shaped by the interests of the dominant, Bourgeois class. As Rylance (1994: 51) notes, Barthes's outlook on his society, in his seminal *Mythologies* (1957) or in *The Fashion system* (1983), is absolutely pessimistic; '[h]umans are continually portrayed as passive victims or willing consumer-dupes'. Hall (1998), influenced by Gramsci's notion of cultural hegemony (Hall 1996), insists that popular culture cannot be understood from the point of view of domination only, but within a dialectic of containment and resistance. Cultural practices are constantly re-appropriated and transformed by various social groups who invest in them their own values and meaning, according to their class interests, as Bourdieu (1999) convincingly demonstrates. Barthes's failure to acknowledge a form of popular culture distinct from traditional culture and emerging from the transformations of mass-consumption society, stems, Rylance (1994) proposes, from a form of disdain towards 'inferior forms' of cultural production, from what McRobbie (1994) also sees as the perpetuation of a high-culture/low-culture divide amongst structuralist theorists.

Paradoxically, Barthes's very creativity and insight indicate how individual agency and resistance may materialise (Rylance 1994). While this is true for the way Barthes deconstructs contemporary myths and exposes how the dominant class try to pass their interests off as universal, it might be even more relevant in relation to features of contemporary media culture. The '*death of the author*' has deposed classical critique and conservative academic authority as regards the way cultural production must be read. The

liberation of subjectivity potentially gives every subject autonomy and legitimacy in asserting their worldview, their voice. Meaning, as the result of a struggle for hegemony, has become more unstable and more likely to be subverted by those who have been kept silent until recent technological developments. The possibility offered by social media, for example, to appropriate, divert or produce meaning and to transform culture is best understood from a poststructuralist viewpoint which sees meaning as flowing from a multiplication of sources.

Part II

In this assignment thus far, I have traced the influences of Barthes's theoretical production and outlined his own contribution to Cultural Studies. The remainder of this essay applies Barthes's critical tools to the analysis of a photograph (figure 1) circulating on the internet.



Figure 1: Modigliani in Nicosia, Cyprus by © Tevfik Ileri

On the denotative plane, this photograph represents three women looking at a painting in what we assume is an art gallery. The painting they are looking at is Modigliani's *Nu Couché* (1917). The three ladies and the model on the painting thus form the four participants of the image (Kress and Van Leeuwen 1996). The characters are photographed from behind; their faces cannot be seen. They wear bright-colour Islamic hooded dresses. Three levels of perspective can be identified: in the background, overhanging the scene is Modigliani's painting. The three women are looking up at it. Two are standing side by side in the middle ground while the third one is standing behind them. She is in the foreground and in the centre of the picture. This latter participant also stands out for two important reasons. Her body seems to be in movement as opposed to that of the other characters. Her shoulders are turned towards the left and her arms are slightly apart while her head is facing the painting as though it has caught her attention and stopped her movement. Secondly, the colours of her dress strikingly match the colours of the bed and cushions Modigliani's model is lying on, establishing a visual (and semantic) link between the two participants. Moreover, the three women are standing in a line from left to right, from the tallest to the shortest, who tilts her head slightly to the right. This marries the line drawn by the model's body, affirming a visual coherence, and suggesting a sympathy among the participants. Finally, the women in the middle ground are both wearing shoulder handbags. While the handbag belonging to the woman on the left is hidden in the folds of her dress, the other, leather made, is very visible.

The meaning of this photograph is conditioned by its modes of production, diffusion and reception. Information about the material conditions of production of the message is hinted by the caption which reads: 'Modigliani in Nicosia, Cyprus by © Tervik Ileri'. The caption anchors the meaning of the photograph in that it limits and orientates its interpretation. It suggests the photograph was taken by a man, with a Turkish name, in a Cypriot art gallery. The presence of handbags questions the character of naturalness or construction of the photographed scene. They appear as everyday life items, suggesting the people in the picture do not pose, that the scene is a genuine capture of real life. As far as diffusion and reception are concerned, it must be noted that the photograph appeared on my Facebook news feed, in January 2016.

On a connotative level, these signs point to a number of sensitive themes in contemporary culture and society, in particular sexism and racism. Below, I contextualise the photograph and show how intertextual references establish these themes.

Modigliani's *Nu Couché*, a text within the text. The painting represents a young woman, nude, her arms and legs apart, in a passive position suggesting she's surrendering her body to her lover. The painting is known for the uproar it triggered, a century ago, as it broke the conventions of nude art and was censored. Here, the naked woman is represented outside conventional allegorical contexts: 1917 censors deemed her looking directly at the viewer was an insult to morality, but above all, she features the attributes of a *real* woman — pubic hair (Krystof 2000). The provocative nature of the painting is part of its identity, and it is re-enacted in the photograph.

The narratives which inform the meaning the picture conveys, the 'citations' it is making, are in direct relation to the current international context, to political discourses

on, and media coverage of, issues such as the war in the Middle-East, migration towards Europe, Islamophobia, terrorist and 'sex attacks' (BBC 2016). These form the different texts that makes the picture signify. In a different political context, this picture would probably not have created a 'buzz'. Indeed, social media allow the multitude to 'publish' (to post, to 'like' and propagate) such images. It can be argued that before Web 2.0, such a photograph, and its subversive content — as I demonstrate below — would probably not have been available to a large public. This manifests a feature of our postmodern condition: meaning can no longer be said to be solely imposed by mainstream discourses, it is actively opposed by counter-discourses emerging from below.

This text, then, contains a political dimension that intends to subvert hegemonic representations. Barthes (1957) shows that hegemonic ideology creates myths, naturalises cultural constructs by concealing their historical dimension. I want to suggest this image does the opposite. It intends to de-naturalise the hegemonic worldview, to de-construct prejudice by juxtaposing elements that do not usually sit well together within dominant, Western ideological representations of the world. In the picture, two forms of Otherness unsettle the discourse of Western supremacy (the Other being the other of Cartesian subjectivity on which Western ideology rests) the 'non-male' and 'non-Christian', which constitute the basis of gender inequalities and racial hierarchies (Grosfoguel 2013).

Thus the photograph brings together, structurally, oppositions and antagonisms. Firstly, the caption to the picture indicates that the scene is taking place in Nicosia, the capital city of a country split into two sovereignties and two cultures. Like much of Southern Europe, Cyprus has been a site of the encounter of Islam and Christianity throughout history. The division of the island symbolises this antagonistic relationship. The encounter of Europe with the non-European world is also betokened, although not as an opposition but as an expression of hybridity, by Modigliani's art, which was greatly influenced by African art and in particular African masks (Krystof 2000). The encounter of the hegemonic subjectivity (the 'white man' dominating art, science and political power) with its Other is finally symbolised by the presence of Muslim women in a museum displaying Western art. Secondly, an opposition clearly established in this photograph is that between modesty, represented by women covering their head, and the nakedness of Modigliani's model. The opposition may be perceived as even more antagonistic: as prudery, grounded in religious traditionalism, and inhibition, freed from moral prescription. The juxtaposition triggers questions relating to the repression of sexuality, and to the place of women in patriarchal social orders. Issues of representation of Islam and of sexuality coalesce to question the viewer. The provocative and subversive nature of Modigliani's painting diffuse in the photograph that suggests there is still something the West represses. While the public representation of sensuality has been acculturated, it is the presence of Islam in the heart of Western culture symbolised by a museum, that poses a problem.

These oppositions question Western prejudiced construction of identity — the West is mature and enlightened, it is a modern, liberal civilisation. Said (1978) shows how the construction of a backward "Other" (the Other of Europe), has been the necessary condition to the construction of a morally superior, Eurocentric "Self": Orien-

talism. Thus, binary oppositions pervade Western view of the world: The East is immature, superstitious, tyrannical, uncivilised, etc. This prejudice is particularly obvious in the way recent events have been portrayed. A certain European identity discourse disavows its century-long discrimination against women in order to better stigmatise Muslim sexism. The image brings together what Orientalism has striven to keep apart: freedom, liberalism, and civilisation on the one hand, and Islam on the other. By bringing together themes that are normally mutually exclusive in a hegemonic Western discourse, this picture renders uncomfortable a Western subject position.

Subject position is also disrupted by the play of glances in the picture. Mulvey (2000: 179) claims that the representation of women, in cinema, reproduces the cultural codes of a male-dominated society and ‘displays’ women for the satisfaction of men’s voyeuristic pleasure, the ‘male gaze’: ‘In a world of sexual imbalance, pleasure in looking has been split between active/male and passive/female’. She argues that women, displayed as erotic objects, satisfy the desire of the male character in the movie, as well as that of the male spectator. The two gazes unify in the construction of a subject position through a process of identification.

Through this photograph, a number of gazes are brought into play. The model is represented in an erotic, passive/female position, offered to the gaze of the male painter: Modigliani; behind the artist, stands, virtually, the gaze of his male patron: Leopold Zborowski (Wikipedia 2016); capturing the scene in the museum is the photographer’s male gaze; and finally, catching up on Facebook news feed, is my own male gaze. Nevertheless, these gazes do not unproblematically unify in the construction of a sexist subject position because they are looking not at a men enjoying the exhibitionism of a woman, but at women.

The body language of the three characters suggest their *active* and attentive engagement with the painting. The fact that we cannot see their facial expressions gives even more salience to their postures. The woman on the right is tilting her head as a sign of intense scrutiny while the central character’s attention has been captured, stopping her movement. Moreover, the colours of her dress establish a strong link with the model, suggesting an identification, not with the male glance, but with the looked-at woman. She is nonetheless looking. Her facial expression, which would reveal the ‘truth’ of her emotions and resolve the tension created by this disturbing construction of identifications, remains a mystery. Desire is a conspicuous theme in this picture. Are the women are looking up *at* the naked model or looking up *to* it. What the women in the photograph desire is a central question, and possibly a source of anxiety for the subject caught in Western colonial ideology.

This interpretation has shown some of the meaning construction mechanisms the photograph relies on, as well as its potentially subversive nature. By bringing together elements that are generally presented as antagonistic in the dominant Western ideology, for example sexual liberalism and Islam, the photograph challenges the prevailing, stereotyped meaning these elements are conventionally attributed. Additionally, the subject position from which meaning deploys is made untenable for a subjectivity shaped by sexist and racist ideologies, due, in part, to the gender roles the photograph unsettles.

Conclusion

In this assignment I have outlined the intellectual context in which Barthes produced his thinking, and shown the influence of Marxism, Saussurean linguistics, structuralism and poststructuralism. I have then focused on Barthes's own contribution to semiotics and on the place of his work in Cultural Studies. Barthes's focus on signifying practices and his anthropological approach of culture and society give him a singular place in social sciences and make him a founder of Cultural Studies.

His work, however, tends to give a bleak vision of individual agency and popular creativity, and to portray popular culture as hopelessly corrupt by capitalism and consumerism (Rylance 1994). In the second part of this essay I have shown that notwithstanding this pessimist stance, the analysis tools Barthes provides to critically engage with media and with texts, can empower readers.

Since *The Death of the Author*, not only writing, but reading is a creative act (Barthes 1977b). The possibilities given by the internet for producing and disseminating texts seem to echo and relay the insights of 1960s poststructuralists. Meaning is no longer the property of the schoolmaster, of the centralised State, or of Capital. Reading can be playful and creative. Meaning can be appropriated, contested, diverted, subverted.

Critical engagement with meaning and new forms of agency provided by digital media open possibilities for a transformation of society. However, control over subjectivities through dominant ideologies remain strong and it falls to education to equip citizens with critical literacy skills.

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